

The Religious Motor of History:

A TNA Critique of Historical Materialism

Author: Claudio Bresciano

Framework: Theory of Axiomatic Necessity (TNA)

Date: May 2026

Abstract

This paper presents a structural critique of historical materialism through the Theory of Axiomatic Necessity (TNA). Against the Marxist thesis that economic infrastructure determines religious and cultural superstructure, this paper argues that **religion constitutes the non-derivable legitimizing structure (N_1) that enables economic dynamics (N_0)**. Archaeological evidence from Bruniquel Cave (~176,000 BP) and Göbekli Tepe (~9600 BC) demonstrates that transcendence, ritual, and symbolic complexity predate—and structurally precede—agricultural surplus and economic complexity. The English case (16th–18th centuries) is analyzed as a **structural sequence**: the collapse of Catholic N_1 under Henry VIII, the fragmentation of legitimizing authority, the emergence of Protestant predestination as a new Selector-trigger generating compulsive economic action, and the rise of capitalism as an **Operator** that collapses existential multiplicity into material evidence of election. The paper concludes that capitalism is not the cause but the **symptom** of a religious vacuum: an Operator without N_1 , generating its own Failure of Local Closure. The contemporary return of young people to Catholic invariants is interpreted not as regression but as **structural recognition** that the capitalist Operator cannot generate its own conditions of realizability.

1. Introduction: The Materialist Inversion

Historical materialism, from Marx to contemporary structural Marxism, rests on a foundational axiom:

The economic base determines the ideological superstructure.

Religion, law, culture, philosophy—these are epiphenomena of material conditions. The mode of production generates the mode of consciousness. Change the economy, and the rest follows.

TNA identifies this as a **category error of derivability**: the attempt to generate N_1 (non-derivable legitimizing structure) from N_0 (operational dynamics). This is structurally impossible. No system can generate its own conditions of legitimacy from internal dynamics alone. This is the **Failure of Local Closure** (Bresciano, 2024).

This paper argues the inverse:

Religion is not the superstructure of economy. Economy is the operationalization of religious structure.

Or more precisely: N_1 (**religious transcendence**) generates the conditions of possibility for N_0 (**economic dynamics**). When N_1 collapses, N_0 does not disappear—it **mutates**, producing new Operators to fill the vacuum. Capitalism is one such mutation.

2. Archaeological Evidence: Transcendence Before Economy

2.1 Bruniquel Cave: Ritual Without Surplus

Bruniquel Cave (France, ~176,000 BP) contains deliberately arranged stalagmites—circles and rectangles—interpreted as **ritual structures**. This predates:

- Agriculture by ~160,000 years
- Permanent settlements by ~150,000 years
- Any conceivable economic surplus

Structural implication: Transcendence (the experience of a reality beyond immediate material utility) is **not generated by** economic conditions. It is a **pre-economic structure** that organizes human collectives around non-utilitarian purposes. The N_1 of ritual precedes the N_0 of production.

2.2 Göbekli Tepe: Symbolism Before Agriculture

Göbekli Tepe (Turkey, ~9600 BC) presents:

- Megalithic pillars of 20+ tons
- Complex symbolic carvings (animals, abstract signs)
- Organized labor requiring coordination of hundreds of individuals
- **All before** the agricultural revolution in the region

The standard narrative: agriculture → surplus → specialization → religion/monumental architecture.

The TNA inversion: **religious structure** → **social coordination** → **agricultural possibility**.

The N_1 of shared transcendence (common ritual, common symbols) generates the **social cohesion** necessary for organized labor. That organized labor then enables agriculture—not the reverse. The symbolic structure is **externally anchored** to the economic system; it does not derive from it.

2.3 The Structural Priority of N_1

These cases are not anomalies. They are **structural signatures**:

SITE	N_1 (TRANSCENDENCE)	N_0 (ECONOMY)	TEMPORAL RELATION
Bruniquel	Ritual structures	None	N_1 precedes N_0 by 160,000 years
Göbekli Tepe	Megalithic religion	Pre-agricultural	N_1 precedes N_0 by millennia

TNA principle: Wherever we find complex N_0 (economy, technology, social organization), we find prior N_1 (religion, ritual, shared transcendence). N_1 is the **enabling condition**, not the derivative product.

3. The English Sequence: A Structural History

The English case (16th–18th centuries) is the clearest laboratory for testing the TNA thesis. Not because England is unique, but because its **religious fracture was sharp, documented, and structurally complete**.

3.1 The Catholic N_1 : Unified Legitimacy

Pre-Reformation England operated under a **monocentric N_1** :

- The Pope as the Selector of doctrinal truth
- The Church as the Operator of sacramental mediation
- The economy as **embedded** in a legitimizing structure that exceeded it

Economic activity was **legitimized by** religious structure. Profit was permissible; usury was regulated; the social order was cosmologically grounded. The N_1 provided **non-derivable realizability**: the assurance that economic action participated in a larger, meaningful structure.

3.2 Henry VIII: The Collapse of N_1

The divorce crisis (1527–1534) was not merely political. It was **structural**:

- Henry VIII rejects papal authority → N_1 **loses its center**
- The Act of Supremacy (1534) → **The monarch becomes the new Selector**
- Dissolution of the monasteries (1536–1541) → **Economic decoupling from Catholic N_1**
- No more taxes to Rome → **Resources remain territorial**

TNA interpretation: This is a **Boundary-Induced Collapse** (Bresciano, 2025). The boundary condition (Henry's need for a male heir) triggers a discontinuity in the legitimizing structure. The previous N_1 (papal authority) cannot absorb the new condition; it collapses. A new N_1 must emerge—or the system enters **non-closure**.

3.3 The Fragmentation of Multiplicity

The English Reformation did not produce a new unified N_1 . It produced **multiplicity**:

- Anglicanism (state-controlled, moderate)
- Puritanism (radical, Calvinist-influenced)
- Catholic recusancy (underground, persecuted)
- Dissenting traditions (Baptists, Quakers, later Methodists)

$\Delta > 1$: Multiple competing legitimizing structures, none with undisputed authority. This is not merely religious pluralism. It is **epistemic and existential multiplicity**: the subject can no longer rely on a single, externally anchored N_1 to legitimize action.

3.4 Predestination: The New Selector-Trigger

Calvinist predestination introduces a **radical structural condition**:

- Salvation is predetermined, unknowable in advance
- The subject cannot **derive** their election from sacraments (Catholic N_1 is gone)
- The subject cannot **derive** their election from good works (works do not cause salvation)
- The only **possible evidence** of election is **material success**

TNA reformulation:

- The Selector (individual consciousness) registers $\Delta > 1$ (am I elect or reprobate?)
- The Selector cannot resolve this multiplicity through internal means (prayer, introspection)
- The Selector **triggers** a compulsive need for external evidence
- The Operator (economic activity, enterprise, accumulation) **executes** the collapse of multiplicity into material signs

This is not "work ethic" as cultural value. It is **structural necessity**: the Operator (capitalism) emerges because the Selector (angst-ridden consciousness) **requires** a mechanism to collapse its unresolved multiplicity.

3.5 Capitalism as Operator Without N_1

The capitalist system that emerges in 17th–18th century England is **not a new N_1** . It is an **Operator** that simulates N_1 -functions:

- Profit replaces sacramental grace as the sign of election
- Enterprise replaces monastic vocation as the form of legitimate action
- Market success replaces divine favor as the evidence of realizability

But this is **simulation, not instantiation**. The capitalist Operator:

- Has **non-derivability** (Axiom O1): profit is not derivable from labor theory alone
- Has **non-unitarity** (Axiom O2): accumulation is irreversible, wealth is not conserved
- Has **discontinuity** (Axiom O3): market crashes, creative destruction, boom-bust cycles

What it **lacks** is the Selector's registration of multiplicity as **existential tension**, and the N_1 -structure that would **legitimize** the collapse. Capitalism executes selection without the phenomenological discharge of necessity. It is an **ungrounded Operator**.

4. The English Miracle: Why England?

The Industrial Revolution occurred in England, not in France, Germany, Spain, or China. Why?

Materialist explanations fail:

- Germany had more coal
- France had larger population and markets

- Spain had more colonial silver
- China had more advanced pre-industrial technology

TNA explanation: England had the **specific structural sequence**:

1. **Complete N₁ collapse** (Henry VIII's break with Rome was sharper than Lutheranism or Gallicanism)
2. **Territorial retention of resources** (no taxes to Rome, monastic wealth confiscated)
3. **Class emergence** (gentry and bourgeoisie as new Selectors, not merely operators)
4. **Naval-military expansion** (new Operators for colonial realizability)
5. **Predestination angst** (Puritan influence strongest in England's commercial classes)
6. **Biblical individualism** (the Word is in the text, not the institution—every subject becomes their own Selector)

The "English miracle" is not economic. It is **structural**: the unique completeness of England's religious fracture created the conditions for an Operator (capitalism) to emerge and **dominate** because no competing N₁ could restrain it.

5. The Capitalist Vacuum: Operator Without Legitimacy

5.1 The Existential Void

Capitalism, as an ungrounded Operator, generates its own **Failure of Local Closure**:

- It produces excedentes without producing **meaning**
- It generates wealth without generating **realizability legitimacy**
- It creates options without creating **selection necessity**

The subject in late capitalism experiences:

- **Multiplicity without tension** (infinite consumer choices, no existential pressure)
- **Execution without trigger** (work, produce, consume—no phenomenological discharge)
- **Realization without feedback** (success is registered as data, not as lived closure)

This is the **vacío existencial** that perdures: the structural condition of an Operator that has outrun its Selector, and a Selector that has lost its N₁.

5.2 The Young and the Invariant

The contemporary return of young people to Catholic practice—despite secularization, despite scandals, despite apparent irrationality—is **not regression**.

It is **structural recognition**.

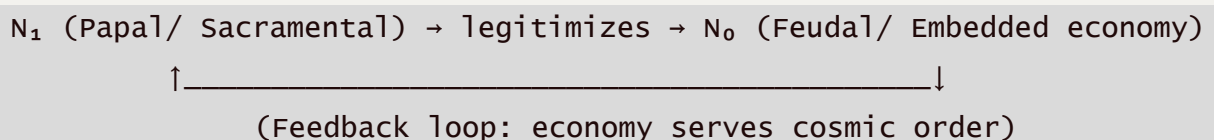
The Catholic invariant offers:

- **N₁ as stability**: a non-derivable legitimizing structure that does not collapse into market fluctuations
- **Selector relief**: the confession, the Eucharist, the liturgical cycle provide **phenomenological feedback** (the experience of closure, of "this is realized")
- **Operator restraint**: Catholic social teaching limits the market's colonization of all life-domains
- **Multiplicity resolution**: the sacraments collapse existential multiplicity into singular, repeated, stable realization

In TNA terms: the young are **reconstructing the N₁→N₀ bridge** that capitalism destroyed. They are not rejecting modernity; they are **repairing its structural non-closure**.

6. Formalization: The Religious-Economic Sequence as TNA Process

6.1 Stage 1: Integrated N₁–N₀ (Catholicism)



Properties:

- N₁ is **monocentric** (single Selector: Pope/Church)
- N₀ is **embedded** (economic action is subordinated to religious legitimacy)
- Closure is **stable** but **low-dynamism** (innovation is suspect)

6.2 Stage 2: N_1 Collapse (Reformation)

N_1 (Papal) —Boundary-induced collapse—→ $\Delta > 1$ (multiple N_1 candidates)
↓
 N_0 decouples, enters non-closure

Properties:

- Boundary condition: Henry VIII's dynastic crisis
- Collapse is **discontinuous** (Axiom O3)
- Multiplicity emerges: Anglican, Puritan, Catholic, Dissenter
- N_0 is **unmoored** (economic action no longer automatically legitimized)

6.3 Stage 3: Selector Trigger (Predestination Angst)

selector (individual consciousness) registers $\Delta > 1$ (election?
reprobation?)
↓
Discharge of necessity: "I must produce evidence"
↓
Trigger sent to Operator (economic activity)

Properties:

- The Selector is **individualized** (Biblical reading, no institutional mediation)
- The trigger is **compulsive** (not chosen, but structurally necessitated)
- The Operator receives the imperative: **collapse multiplicity into material signs**

6.4 Stage 4: Operator Emergence (Capitalism)

Operator (capitalist enterprise) executes selection:
- Investment vs. non-investment
- Production vs. non-production
- Accumulation vs. consumption
↓
Output: material success as pseudo- N_1 ("I am elect because I profit")

Properties:

- The Operator is **formally complete** (satisfies O1–O3)
- The Operator is **ontologically incomplete** (lacks N_1 , simulates it with profit)
- The system enters **dynamic non-closure**: growth without legitimization

6.5 Stage 5: Structural Recognition (Return to Invariant)

operator (capitalism) reveals its non-closure:

- wealth without meaning
- Success without realization
- Options without necessity

↓

selector (young subjects) recognizes missing N_1

↓

Reconstruction: Catholic invariant as restabilizing N_1

Properties:

- Not a return to Stage 1 (the invariant is now **chosen**, not inherited)
 - The $N_1 \rightarrow N_0$ bridge is **rebuilt consciously** as structural repair
 - The Operator is **re-embedded** (capitalism continues, but is **limited** by N_1)
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7. Comparative Structural Analysis

7.1 Why Not France?

France had:

- A stronger centralized state (N_0 was already autonomous)
- Gallicanism (N_1 was nationalized, not fragmented)
- A Catholic Counter-Reformation that **restored** N_1 (Selector: monarchy + Church)

The French sequence: N_1 survives (weakened, but intact) → N_0 remains embedded → no compulsive Operator emergence → **no Industrial Revolution first.**

7.2 Why Not Spain?

Spain had:

- Massive colonial wealth (N_0 without N_1 constraint)
- Catholic N_1 **reinforced** by Counter-Reformation
- The Inquisition as Operator of doctrinal purity

The Spanish sequence: N_1 is **too strong** → N_0 is **over-constrained** → economic dynamism is **suspect** → wealth is **spent**, not invested → **no capitalist emergence**.

7.3 Why Not China?

China had:

- Advanced technology, large markets, extensive trade
- Confucianism as **immanent** N_1 (cosmic order without transcendence)
- The Mandate of Heaven as **cyclical**, not progressive

The Chinese sequence: N_1 is **immanent and stable** → no existential angst → no compulsive trigger → no Operator emergence → **no Industrial Revolution** (until imported from the West).

7.4 The TNA Generalization

Industrial capitalism emerges only where:

1. N_1 **collapses** (not merely weakens)
2. The collapse is **territorially complete** (resources remain local)
3. A new Selector emerges (individualized, angst-driven)
4. The new Selector **triggers** an Operator (economic activity as evidence-seeking)
5. The Operator is **not restrained** by a competing N_1

England is the **only** case where all five conditions were met simultaneously.

8. Philosophical Implications

8.1 Against Materialism

Historical materialism is not merely empirically wrong (the archaeology contradicts it). It is **structurally incoherent**:

- It attempts to derive N_1 from N_0
- It treats religion as **epiphenomenon** of the "real" economic base
- It cannot explain why **the same economic conditions** produce different religious outcomes (England vs. Spain vs. China)

TNA explains: N_1 **is not derived from** N_0 ; N_1 **enables** N_0 . The variation in economic outcomes is explained by **variation in N_1 structure**, not by variation in material conditions.

8.2 Against Weber (Partially)

Max Weber's *Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1905) is the closest precursor to this paper. Weber identified the **correlation** between Protestantism and capitalism. But he:

- Treated it as **cultural** (ethos, psychology), not **structural**
- Did not explain **why England specifically**
- Did not connect to archaeological evidence of N_1 -priority
- Did not predict the **return to invariant**

TNA formalizes Weber's intuition: the "ethic" is not cultural preference but **structural necessity**—the Selector's compulsive trigger in the absence of N_1 .

8.3 The Nature of Modernity

Modernity is not the "disenchantment of the world" (Weber). It is the **Operatorization of the world**: the replacement of N_1 by Operators that simulate its functions without its structure.

The "reenchantment" we observe today is not nostalgia. It is **structural repair**: the recognition that Operators without N_1 produce non-closure, and the deliberate reconstruction of N_1 as **stability condition**.

9. Conclusion: The Motor and the Machine

Historical materialism inverts the structural relation between religion and economy. It treats the machine (economy) as the motor, and the meaning-structure (religion) as the epiphenomenon.

TNA restores the correct architecture:

Religion is the motor. Economy is the machine.

Or more precisely:

- **N₁ (religion/transcendence)** is the **non-derivable legitimizing structure** that makes action meaningful and realizable
- **N₀ (economy/production)** is the **operational dynamics** that execute action within the conditions set by N₁
- **The Selector (consciousness/angst)** is the **trigger** that registers when N₁ is absent and discharges the necessity of new action
- **The Operator (capitalism/enterprise)** is the **executor** that collapses multiplicity into realized states

The English sequence demonstrates this with unique clarity:

1. **Motor running** (Catholic N₁)
2. **Motor stalls** (Reformation collapse)
3. **Trigger fires** (predestination angst)
4. **Machine accelerates** (capitalism)
5. **Machine overheats** (existential vacuum)
6. **Motor rebuilt** (return to invariant)

The Marxist prediction—capitalism generates its own superstructure, religion will wither—was **backward**. Capitalism is the **superstructure** of a religious collapse. And when that superstructure fails to generate its own legitimacy, the **base** (religion) returns—not as regression, but as **structural necessity**.

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